

Over

In a rare occurrence, the PC and PS2 versions of *Splinter Cell: Double Agent* are actually two completely different games. The story remains the same, but is told differently, complete with different missions. The PC and Xbox 360 versions are “next-gen” and the PS2 and Xbox are the (seemingly shunned) “current-gen” versions. We’ve noticed that the current-gen version isn’t getting Ubisoft’s love the way the next-gen is, which is a shame.

The PC version is definitely more stylised, and the PS2 version takes the academic tell-it-like-it-is approach. While the former makes for more entertainment, I prefer the latter, which doesn’t leave any unanswered questions in the overall picture.

The first mission is easily the best training mission for any game we’ve played here. Not only does it tell you exactly what to do, it also walks you through the procedure, prompting you to hit the appropriate controls when the time comes. You’re thus taken through every single move Fisher can pull off—a feature sadly lacking on the PC.

The PS2 version also retains the HUD, which tells you how exposed Sam is or how much noise he’s making—thankfully. It takes a lot of the guesswork out



ATOM CLANCY'S SPLINTER CELL DOUBLE AGENT

of the game, and is one less headache to manage. You’ll also be using gadgets more often, including the trusty EMP gun to disable cameras and lights.

On its own, the PS2 version is an excellent game. It may not look as good, but the gameplay is pretty solid. The trust meter is obviously there—tip the balance too much to one side and you’ll have an intense, time-limited mission to complete to show that you’re still loyal to the other. The difficulty is a tad forgiving—while staying stealthy is challenging, once you’re exposed, the enemy does take its time to get an accurate shot at you. Unlike the PC version, your health doesn’t regenerate over time—you’ll need the same old medkits—and this adds another bit of tension to the experience. Level design is fantastic as usual, and you’re presented with ample opportunity to pull off some crazy, acrobatic kills—upside down neck-breaks, split-jumps and a whole lot more.

One nag with the PS2 version is that the console’s age is clearly showing—save and load times are painful, especially considering that you’ll need to save your game compulsively. You’ll also be overwriting each save, so there’s no going back to a better time. Also say bye-bye to the prospect of replaying the game from a favourite point once you’re done.

The soundtrack is brilliant, and music fades in the second you’re spotted, adding to the already tense atmosphere of the game. Overall, this makes for a good buy if you’ve hung on to your PS2 and have found nothing wrong with the old *Chaos Theory*-style gameplay.

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PS2 Rating: 8/10
PC Rating: 8/10
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Developer: Ubisoft Shanghai
Distributor: E-Xpress Interactive
Contact: sales@e-xpressindia.com
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Requirements (PC): Pentium 3 2.4 GHz, 512 MB RAM, Direct X9.0c ready 128 MB graphics card (at least SM 2.0 support)